Cuteness as a Mechanism of Access: The Hyperfeminine Cyberdeck Community as a Case Study in Maker Culture

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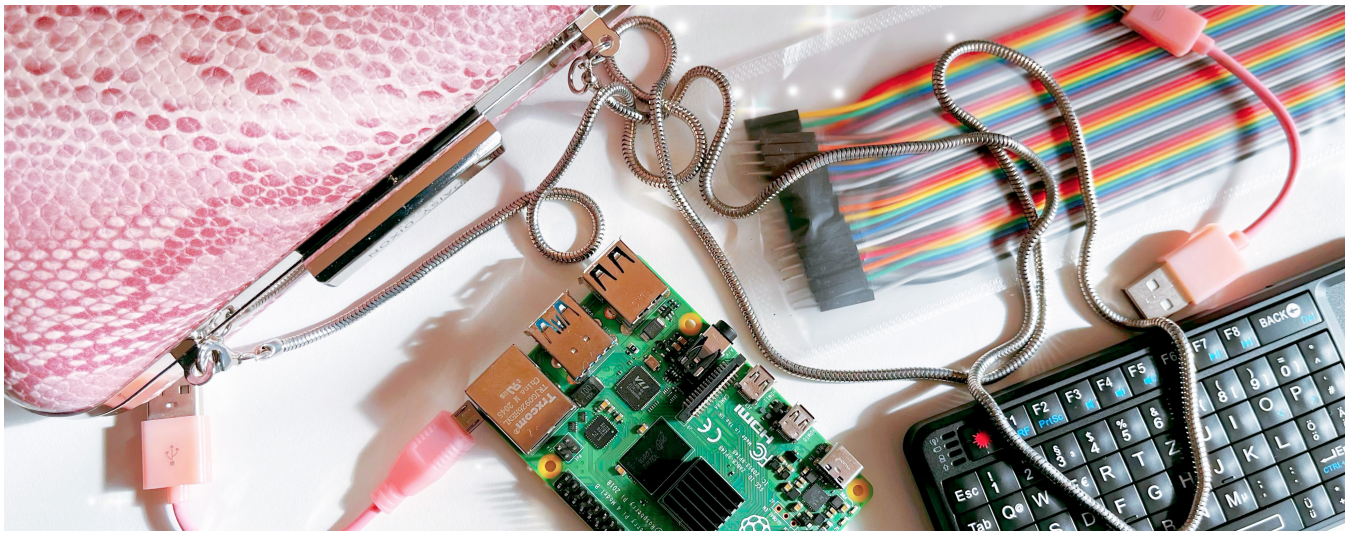


Figure 1: *Initial hardware components and handbag enclosure prepared for an exploratory cyberdeck build by the author.*

Abstract

As contemporary technology becomes increasingly proprietary and corporatized, participation in technical spaces feels exclusionary to many. Simultaneously, a counter-movement has emerged: hyperfeminine creators building custom, portable computers known as "cyberdecks," defined by a playful, cute aesthetic. Rather than technical intimidation, this whimsical visual language acts as an emotional invitation, encouraging creators to build hardware and openly share technical knowledge through tutorials and collaborative spaces. This raises the question of whether cuteness itself functions as a mechanism of access. This paper examines the hyperfeminine cyberdeck community as a case study, drawing on cute studies and feminist Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) theory to descriptively analyze how aesthetic identity shapes participation in DIY tech spaces. While cuteness and maker culture have each been studied separately, their intersection remains unexplored. This paper offers an initial connection between these two fields, with broader implications for inclusion, diversity, and agency in tech and design culture.

1. Introduction

Contemporary consumer electronics are frequently designed as proprietary systems that restrict what users can change [Sha]. In response, a distinct counter-movement has emerged: the hyperfeminine cyberdeck community. This community is described as mostly led by female creators [Poi26, Whi26] who build custom, portable computers (cyberdecks) and share their projects on social media. Since early 2026, as Kara Shanahan [Sha] documents, cyberdeck building has spread widely on TikTok, and many builds share a playful, cute visual language [Poi26]. In contrast to the sterile, monochromatic aesthetic of commercial consumer tech, the creations and overall styling of this community are defined by a whimsical and cute aesthetic. In doing so, these makers offer an alternative to corporate big tech: their devices are customizable, of-

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ten built from reused parts [Sha], and rendered socially inviting and accessible through the deliberate use of cuteness.

Commentators describe tech as designed to feel intimidating and out of reach, especially for women, queer people and other marginalized groups [Poi26]. In this paper, *elite* and *elitist* refer to two overlapping structures: a commercial industry that designs sealed, uniform devices, and a hacker and maker culture that critics describe as coded masculine and technically gatekeeping [Poi26]. The community positions itself as an alternative to these structures, not as a direct competitor of the industry. Analyzing countermovements that actively democratize technology offers crucial insights into how aesthetic practices can invite marginalized groups into technical spaces, thereby contributing to a broader diversification of tech culture. Analyzing these dynamics is highly relevant to interaction design, maker culture, and the fundamental question of who is empowered to contribute to the technological landscape of the future.

The contemporary revival of "cyberdecks", a hardware trend rooted in the science fiction of forty years ago, gained wide attention in early 2026, catalyzed primarily by the viral videos of creator Ube Boobey [Sha]. Maker media such as Raspberry Pi also noted this wave of attention in April 2026 [Whi26]. Ube Boobey built a working single-board computer into a vintage handbag decorated with gold ornaments and plants (see Figure 2) [Boo26].

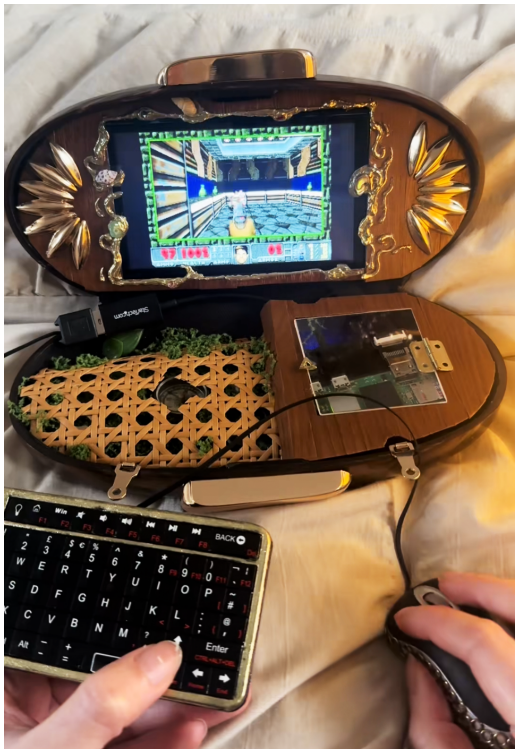


Figure 2: *Mermaid Cyberdeck 2.0 built into a vintage handbag by creator Ube Boobey. Screenshot from TikTok [Boo26].*

Shanahan reports that Ube Boobey had never attempted a technical project before but saw a cyberdeck as a rewarding side project; her deck stores films, music, maps, books, around 1,000 Wikipedia articles and a few games such as "Doom 3" offline [Sha]. This phenomenon invites a central research question: How does cuteness operate as a mechanism of access in maker culture, and what does the hyperfeminine cyberdeck community illustrate about this dynamic?

To address this inquiry, this paper provides:

- A descriptive empirical characterization of the hyperfeminine cyberdeck community as a contemporary sociotechnical phenomenon, contrasted with the cyberdeck imagined in Gibson's Neuromancer;
- A theoretical synthesis of Cute Studies [Dal] and Feminist Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) [Bar], conceptualizing cuteness as an aesthetic mechanism of access;
- Practical implications for interaction design and maker culture on how playful aesthetics can lower barriers to hardware participation.

Methodologically, this paper combines academic literature on cute studies and feminist design theory with qualitative observations of publicly available social media content from the cyberdeck community. This material is examined through a single descriptive case study and an interpretive reading of the observed posts.

2. Related Work

This study builds upon and synthesizes several bodies of literature across aesthetic theory, feminist design, and contemporary technology subcultures.

Joshua Paul Dale's *Irresistible* provides the psychological and cultural framework for understanding how cute aesthetics elicit powerful emotional, behavioral, and affiliative responses [Dal]. Dale demonstrates that cuteness functions as a dynamic strategy of social engagement rather than merely as a superficial aesthetic trait. This insight serves as the primary theoretical foundation for analyzing how whimsical design characteristics can democratize technical practices, rendering maker spaces emotionally inviting and socially accessible.

To examine how such aesthetic invitations translate into design and interaction, this study draws on Bardzell's foundational framework for Feminist Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) [Bar]. Bardzell establishes that technology design is never value-neutral, as interactive systems inevitably encode assumptions about the identities of their intended users. Her framework offers a crucial analytical lens for examining how aesthetic choices and design qualities can signal inclusion or exclusion within technical environments.

To ground the historical and symbolic origins of the hardware itself, Arulmurugan and Jinnah analyze the essential cyberpunk elements in William Gibson's *Neuromancer* [AJ]. Their characterization of the cyberdeck as a highly individualized tool of subversive, anti-authoritarian digital rebellion provides a historical reference point against which the contemporary hyperfeminine cyberdeck resurgence can be contrasted.

Finally, contemporary media coverage documents the mod-

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ern, hyperfeminine inflection of this hardware movement. Shanahan [Sha] frames cyberdeck building as an ethical, customizable alternative to big tech, quoting builders and scholars who stress autonomy, sustainable reuse of parts and offline media. Raspberry Pi's own maker news likewise points to a new wave of female makers building cyberdecks and to the attention it has received [Whi26].

3. Method

This paper uses a qualitative, interpretive approach. Academic literature serves as the theoretical framework. The observational material consists of publicly available Instagram posts by creators who build or discuss cyberdecks, including build showcases, tutorials and workshop announcements, complemented by TikTok videos of the central creator Ube Boobey. The posts were collected through exploratory browsing between March and September 2026 and were not sampled systematically. Only public posts were considered, and no comments or private accounts were analyzed. The corpus comprises 25 saved social media posts (1 workshop, 3 tutorials, 16 build showcases, 5 Tamagotchi-style and hairclip builds), complemented by 2 workshop event pages. The list of observed posts is available from the author on request. The study is a single descriptive case study.

4. Theoretical and Historical Context

This section traces cuteness, the cyberdeck concept and today's community in turn, before Section 5 analyses them together.

The Japanese concept of *kawaii*, which can be translated to cute, serves as a sociopolitical tool, creating spaces for self-discovery beyond traditional gender roles and alleviating social pressure in highly regulated societies [Dal].

Today, the ubiquity of cuteness in Japan's public spaces reflects a sweeping aesthetic transformation of functional objects [Dal]. Crucially, *kawaii* operates within a far broader semantic field than its restrictive English counterpart, "cute" [Dal]. Consequently, the sociological debate surrounding this phenomenon is characterized by a persistent tension between infantile regression and emancipatory potential.

Critics like Takashi Murakami interpret the *kawaii* phenomenon as an expression of Japan's post-1945 national emasculation; in this view, the nation unconsciously retreated into cuteness to appear non-threatening to the occupying U.S. forces [Dal]. Conversely, a compelling counterargument frames *kawaii* as an active vehicle for agency: for women and increasingly men this aesthetic provides an escape from rigid gender expectations and the intense performance pressure of the modern workplace, ultimately dismantling restrictive social barriers [Dal].

Rather than a trivial, marginal phenomenon, cuteness operates as a highly functional aesthetic strategy. It has evolved from a purely biological survival mechanism into a global language of social engagement [Dal]. By refining instinctive evolutionary stimuli into a cultural practice, *kawaii* links our biological heritage with complex modern societies. As an instrument of social affiliation, it enables a playful reappropriation of the world [Dal].

4.1. The Playful Dimension: "Whimsical Cuteness"

Beyond classic cuteness, which relies on the biological baby schema (*Kindchenschema*) to elicit nurturing behaviors, exists a second, equally functional category: whimsical cuteness [Dal]. While conventional cute stimuli encourage protection and caregiving, this playful variant sparks a direct desire for interaction, pleasure, and collaborative play [Dal].

4.2. Historical Context: The Cyberdeck as a Tool for Subversion and Individuality

In William Gibson's 1984 novel *Neuromancer*, the cyberdeck serves as the technological interface projecting the hacker's disembodied consciousness into the "consensual hallucination" of the Matrix. The device's design reflects a subversive DIY aesthetic and technological individuality; rather than relying on mass-produced industrial goods, the characters operate highly personalized systems. This is exemplified by the protagonist, Case, who navigates complex data structures using a custom cyberspace deck. This physical-neural fusion, achieved through neural interfaces embedded directly into the nervous system, challenges the traditional notion of technology as a purely external tool. Gibson highlights this intimate connection linguistically through the metaphor of the "flesh of the console," which mottles like the dying petals of a flower. The cyberdeck thus becomes an organic, personalized extension of the user. [AJ]

Furthermore, the device symbolizes digital rebellion against a repressive, corporate-controlled world order. In a dystopia where transnational corporations like Tessier-Ashpool monopolize power and the flow of information, hacking emerges as a vital act of self-assertion. The hacker group, who call themselves "Console Cowboys," utilize their decks within a decidedly anti-authoritarian subculture. By entering the Matrix, these characters reclaim personal agency in a world under constant surveillance. Hacker culture in the novel thus serves as a lens to examine how technology can empower the individual against seemingly insurmountable, systemic forces. [AJ] Neuromancer serves here as a cultural reference point, not as empirical evidence: the term cyberdeck originates in fiction, while real DIY cyberdecks were already covered on Raspberry Pi's blog in 2020 [Whi26].

4.3. Today's Cyberdeck Community: Collective Appropriation, Aesthetics, and Shared Practice

Shanahan reports that cyberdecks were mainly seen as internet doomsday devices because of their offline capabilities, and describes Ube Boobey as being at the helm of the cyberdeck explosion on TikTok [Sha].

In the observed posts, visual identity often seems to come first (see Section 5.2) [Emm26, Sum26]. Shanahan reports inspiration from the colorful electronics of the 2000s and the hyper-feminine gadgets of *Totally Spies*, set against a decade in which devices became more minimalistic and "designed for no one" [Sha]. Ube Boobey describes the design philosophy as scrap-tech, meaning reusing parts and buying secondhand, often around single-board computers such as the Raspberry Pi [Sha].

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Shanahan quotes philosopher Annette Zimmermann, who argues that builders model how people without a computer science PhD can engage with technology in a deep and meaningful way that questions existing power imbalances [Sha].

4.4. Contrast: Technological Escapism Then vs. Now

A direct comparison between Gibson's dystopian vision and contemporary maker culture reveals shifts in how cyberdecks are imagined, built, and used:

- **From the "Console Cowboy" to a Collective of Makers:** In Gibson's work, the hacker is a highly specialized, isolated, and predominantly male lone wolf (the "Console Cowboy") who uses the deck as a tool for criminal survival in the shadow of global corporations [AJ]. It is worth noting that the term "Console Cowboy" carries problematic connotations rooted in a masculine frontier mythology that historically excluded the very communities now reclaiming the technology. In contrast, contemporary makers are described as mostly female [Poi26] and as people long diminished by dominant tech culture who now imagine something different [Sha].
- **From Tactical Cases to rom Tactical Cases to Handbag Cases:** The physical design of these devices reflects this aesthetic and ideological transformation. While the classic cyberpunk deck is a functional, often martial tool optimized for corporate espionage and data theft [AJ], contemporary feminine cyberdecks are playful, expressive works of art. By reusing parts and repurposing for example hard-shell purses as cases [Sha], these builders move away from the impersonal design of industrial technology.
- **From the Nervous System to Analog Resistance:** In *Neuromancer*, humans and machines merge biologically through brain implants and cranial jacks, conceptually leaving the organic body behind [AJ]. Conversely, the contemporary DIY scene rejects this disembodiment. Building a device lets makers understand what it does and why [Sha], which restores a sense of autonomy.
- **From Virtual Withdrawal to Offline Media Sovereignty:** Gibson's protagonist, Case, escapes the bleakness of the physical world by retreating into the virtual reality of the Matrix, a process that isolates him psychologically [AJ]. Today's cyberdeck builders, on the contrary, use their custom devices as a refuge *from* platform dependence. Some builders construct devices meant to evade surveillance infrastructure, for example off-grid communication via Meshtastic, and offline media libraries give them freedom over their media consumption [Sha].

Table 1 summarizes these shifts.

	Neuromancer (fiction)	**Contemporary**
Aesthetic	Rugged, utilitarian	Cute, hyperfeminine
Community	Male-dominated	Mostly female-led
Goal	Virtual immersion	Community building
Access	Technical elite	Aesthetic invitation

Table 1: *Comparison of the Neuromancer cyberdeck (fiction) and contemporary cyberdecks.*

5. Analysis

5.1. Cuteness as an Invisible Mechanism of Access

The hyperfeminine cyberdeck community operates, perhaps paradoxically, through its very invisibility. Because the aesthetic language of this movement is coded as cute, whimsical, and explicitly feminine, it is rarely perceived by dominant tech institutions as a serious technological intervention. Ngai describes cuteness as an aesthetic that depends on an imbalance of power between viewer and object and that is explicitly about the appeal of powerlessness [Nga12, pp. 54, 58]. Aesthetically, the movement is vibrant and trendy, but it incorporates visual markers that have historically been marginalized within Western paradigms. Individuals expressing hyperfeminine or "girly" aesthetics may face prejudice that underestimates their technical competence. Yet, this marginalization is precisely what renders cuteness effective as a mechanism of access. As Bardzell [Bar] argues, interaction design always encodes implicit assumptions about who the intended user is. The hyperfeminine cyberdeck inverts this normative logic: by designing explicitly for themselves rather than for a presumed universal user, these creators produce artifacts that signal immediate belonging to communities previously excluded from maker culture.

Dale's [Dal] concept of "whimsical cuteness" is particularly illuminating in this context. Unlike conventional cuteness, which primarily triggers caregiving and protective impulses, whimsical cuteness activates an innate desire for interaction, pleasure, and collaborative play. The cyberdecks constructed by this community function in precisely this manner: they invite engagement not through technical intimidation or elitist performance, but through aesthetic delight and curiosity. This dynamic is especially significant because Western culture largely replaces playful, discovery-based learning with institutionalized labor and formal instruction following adolescence, effectively delegitimizing play among adults. Whimsical cuteness bypasses this cultural barrier by re-sanctioning playful experimentation. Ultimately, a vintage handbag housing a Raspberry Pi communicates, even before any technical explanation, a profound message of inclusion: that technology can be reappropriated by and explicitly designed for communities historically excluded from tech culture.

5.2. Form-First as a Radical Counter-Model

Where commercial technology companies produce sealed, uniform devices optimized for mass appeal, the hyperfeminine cyberdeck community can be analyzed as practicing a form-first approach to hardware: aesthetic vision precedes and directly shapes technical implementation. This practice explicitly embodies Bardzell's quality of pluralism in feminist HCI [Bar]. Each custom cyberdeck is singular, reflecting the personal identity, values, and specific needs of its builder rather than the standardized assumptions of a commercial manufacturer. This comparison concerns design logic, not economic equivalence: the community neither competes with the industry nor claims to replace it.

This form-first methodology may lower the perceived barrier to entry into hardware hacker culture. Shanahan reports that Ube Boobey had never undertaken a technical project of this kind before [Sha], and Raspberry Pi observes that a new generation of

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makers seems to compete over who can fit a Raspberry Pi into the strangest casing [Whi26]. Both observations are consistent with an aesthetics first route into hardware. The cute artifact can act as a catalyst and motivation for technical learning, inverting the traditional assumption that technical competence must precede creative expression. Furthermore, the strong visual identity fosters an immediate sense of social affiliation among those who resonate with this aesthetic, which may help explain the growing visibility of this subculture.

5.3. Community as Identity, Not Virtual Escape

The original cyberdeck in Gibson's *Neuromancer* served as a tool of individual escape: a device that projected the user's disembodied consciousness away from the physical world and into the Matrix [AJ]. This escapist paradigm strongly mirrors modern corporate visions of virtual immersion (such as Meta's Metaverse), where technology seeks to replace rather than enrich physical reality.

The contemporary hyperfeminine cyberdeck inverts this logic entirely. Rather than enabling virtual escape, it generates tangible physical community; rather than dissolving identity, it consolidates it. In the observed posts, builders share tutorials and workshop announcements and invite others to join [kri26,sag26]. Workshops beyond social media point the same way: a technical museum invites first-time makers and offers "emotional support" [Tec26], and a London workshop requires no prior electronics experience [Isl26]. Knowledge circulates largely online, but the resulting device is physical and under the user's own control, so the contrast lies in dependence on platforms and algorithms, not in avoiding the internet. Rather than seeking disembodiment in a virtual sphere, this practice re-anchors digital computing within the tangible, material world.

This distinction holds significant implications for maker culture more broadly. Cuteness here functions not as a passive retreat from societal pressure, but as an active mode of re-engagement with technology on transformed terms. For marginalized groups in particular, the movement offers a peaceful and creative claim to technical space—one that bypasses confrontation in favor of aesthetic invitation and collective knowledge-sharing.

6. Discussion

6.1. Why Now? The Historical Moment

The emergence of the hyperfeminine cyberdeck community is by no means coincidental. Rather, it arises at a pivotal historical juncture: a moment when mainstream technology is becoming simultaneously more powerful, opaque, and exclusionary. As large technology companies increasingly force users into their own software [Sha], and as tech controlled by a homogeneous group shuts out some of its most imaginative users [Sha], barriers to participation remain high for marginalized groups. Institutions echo this framing: a technical museum presents cyberdeck building as a way to reduce dependence on multinational corporations and on AI features installed without consent [Tec26]. The hyperfeminine cyberdeck movement can thus be understood as a response to this corporate dynamic: a reclamation of technical agency through aesthetic and material means at the exact moment when such agency is becoming increasingly difficult to access through conventional, institutional pathways.

6.2. The Underestimated Power of Cute

One of the most striking aspects of this movement is its capacity to operate beneath the threshold of institutional recognition. Because its aesthetic language is coded as cute, whimsical, and explicitly feminine, and because these qualities are historically associated with childhood and routinely dismissed as non-serious, it is rarely perceived by dominant tech institutions as a serious technological intervention. This invisibility may be the primary source of the movement's strategic effectiveness: it does not need recognition by dominant structures to exert power. By remaining legible merely as a trend or hobby community, the scene can cultivate autonomy and knowledge-sharing without triggering institutional resistance or co-optation.

This dynamic aligns with a broader historical pattern documented by Dale [Dal], wherein cuteness has consistently functioned as an effective mode of social affiliation, negotiation, and cultural reappropriation. This historical trajectory spans from the ancient domestication of wild wolves into companion animals to the emergence of the *kawaii* movement as a response to Japan's post-war social pressures, and the subsequent global expansion of icons like Hello Kitty [Dal]. Seen against this history, cuteness in cyberdecks is not an isolated fashion choice but a familiar social strategy applied to a new field: technical objects. The cute, highly customized designs of contemporary cyberdecks represent the next evolution in this continuum: the aesthetic transformation of complex technical artifacts as a strategy for reclaiming sociotechnical agency.

6.3. Reclaiming Technical Agency: The Dialectic of Past and Present

The stark contrast between Gibson's 1984 cyberpunk vision and the 2026 hyperfeminine cyberdeck movement illuminates a fundamental shift in how technological subversion is conceptualized. Where early cyberpunk imagined resistance as an isolated, masculine struggle within a disembodied virtual matrix [AJ], today's creators execute resistance through physical, embodied, and collective practice. This evolution directly instantiates Bardzell's [Bar] core feminist interaction design qualities, most notably *pluralism* and *participation*. By centering subjective aesthetic desires over corporate standardization, these makers reject universalizing design paradigms in favor of pluralistic, self-authored hardware artifacts. Far from a purely retro-nostalgic exercise, this juxtaposition demonstrates how contemporary subcultures actively subvert historical tropes of male-dominated technological mastery to construct inclusive, non-hierarchical spaces for participation.

6.4. Limitations and Critical Reflections

Several limitations of this study merit explicit acknowledgment. First, the hyperfeminine cyberdeck community remains a relatively niche sociotechnical phenomenon. While its visibility appears to be expanding, it is still largely confined to specific subcultural corners of creative internet culture. The observational material was

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gathered through exploratory browsing rather than systematic sampling, so the findings describe patterns in the examined posts and should not be generalized. The study also cannot isolate the effect of cuteness from the general openness of maker culture, since earlier builds with other aesthetics were likewise shared with files and tutorials [Whi26]. Visibility and participation may also differ: many people watch cyberdeck content, but it is unclear how many build their own. The term "cyberdeck" remains unfamiliar to many people, and the movement's long-term trajectory beyond communities already oriented toward DIY aesthetics remains uncertain. Whether this movement signifies a lasting cultural paradigm shift or a transient microtrend, comparable to the rapid succession of aesthetic cycles in digital fashion, cannot yet be conclusively determined. Extended longitudinal observation will be required to assess the structural longevity of the movement.

Second, this study is subject to researcher positionality and potential bias. As an investigator who finds this subculture genuinely innovative and politically resonant, I do not claim the stance of a detached, value-neutral observer. The movement's aesthetic and emancipatory dimensions align closely with my own research interests and values, which inevitably influenced both the selection of empirical examples and the framing of the qualitative analysis. Furthermore, my perspective is enriched by firsthand practitioner insights gained through constructing an exploratory handbag cyberdeck prototype in a separate practical project. While this paper itself is framed as a qualitative case study rather than a formal practice-based research project, this hands-on experience provided valuable contextual understanding of hardware assembly, material sourcing, and aesthetic customization. Future research would benefit significantly from a broader spectrum of perspectives, including critical external observers as well as individuals who encounter cyberdecks without prior familiarity with DIY maker culture.

6.5. Future Work

Several promising avenues for future inquiry emerge from this exploratory study. First, conducting qualitative semi-structured interviews with community members would yield deeper empirical insights into how participants themselves articulate the nexus between aesthetic identity, gender expression, and technical learning. Second, a longitudinal study tracking the community's evolution over time would help determine whether hyperfeminine hardware hacking represents an enduring subcultural shift or a temporary aesthetic moment.

Finally, future research could build upon this initial practitioner experience by adopting a formalized, practice-based autoethnographic methodology. Such an experiential approach could systematically uncover technical, material, and affective dimensions of hardware tinkering that remain invisible from a purely observational, third-person perspective.

7. Conclusion

This paper set out to investigate the central research question: *How does cuteness operate as a mechanism of access in maker culture, and what does the hyperfeminine cyberdeck community illustrate about this dynamic?*

By synthesizing cute studies with feminist Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) theory, this study suggests that cuteness can operate as a multi-faceted mechanism of technological access through three functions:

1. **Aesthetic Decoupling and Emotional Invitation:** Drawing on the concept of whimsical cuteness [Dal], cute aesthetics replace technical intimidation with playfulness and curiosity. This dynamic may lower psychological barriers to entry, re-sanctioning hands-on experimentation and discovery-based learning in adulthood.
2. **Inversion of the Normative User Model:** Cuteness serves as a vehicle for self-expression that explicitly signals belonging to marginalized groups. By designing for themselves rather than a presumed universal (and implicitly male) user, creators reject corporate standardization in favor of design pluralism [Bar].
3. **Stealth Subversion:** Operating beneath institutional scrutiny, cute aesthetics allow subcultures to cultivate technical autonomy, offline media sovereignty, and non-hierarchical knowledge-sharing without triggering corporate co-optation or hostility.

The hyperfeminine cyberdeck community serves as an illustrative case study of this paradigm. By transforming custom-built computers made from reused parts into inviting cultural artifacts, these creators demonstrate that hardware tinkering can be liberated from its historically masculine, elitist connotations. In doing so, the community redefines what it means to participate in tech culture, offering a compelling model for future research at the intersection of design, inclusion, and sociotechnical agency.

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